Unit 1 — British Cultural Anchors

Track E · Klasse 11 · Niveau E (Basisfach / Leistungsfach)

Learning objectives I

- *I can read a short cultural-history essay on a British anchor (the welfare state, the BBC, or the National Trust) and identify the writer's argumentative move.*
- *I can use formal academic discourse markers (*by contrast, accordingly, in this regard, more specifically*).*
- *I can write a 250-word cultural-essay paragraph that goes past tourist-image cliché.*

Lead-in I

Klasse 11 opens with three short cultural-history essays: one on the BBC, one on the post-1945 welfare state, one on the National Trust. The class read all three, then argued for forty minutes about which one was the *most British*. The teacher said: *correct answer — none of them on its own*.

Vocabulary I

- charter
- mandate
- public-service
- broadcaster
- licence fee
- devolved
- post-war
- founding moment
- settlement
- institutional resilience
- soft power

Reading I

Reading — *The BBC, in Three Sentences*

The BBC was founded in 1922 as a private company and incorporated by Royal Charter in 1927. Its public-service mandate, often summarised as inform, educate, entertain, has been the source of constant argument and constant funding fights. By contrast with most national broadcasters, it is funded by a household licence fee — a model that is, accordingly, both unusual and politically vulnerable.

Discourse markers (formal academic)

by contrast / accordingly / in this regard / more specifically / it is worth noting that / it follows that / on this account / to put it differently.

Reading II

Vocabulary — cultural-history register
charter, mandate, public-service, broadcaster, licence fee, devolved, post-war, founding moment, settlement, institutional resilience, soft power.

Practise I

Niveau E — controlled

1. Choose discourse marker: *(contrast)* → ___ ; *(consequence)* → ___ ; *(specification)* → ___ .
2. Match: charter → founding document; licence fee → funding model; soft power → cultural influence.

Niveau E — productive

3. Build 4 sentences about a British anchor using 4 different discourse markers.

Your turn I

Cultural-essay paragraph, 250 words. Pick one British anchor (BBC / NHS / National Trust / Parliament). Write a single argumentative paragraph with one claim, two pieces of evidence, and one concession. Use 4 academic discourse markers.

Sample

The BBC is often described, accurately and lazily, as the most British institution. The accurate part is that the household licence fee places the BBC, by contrast with most national broadcasters, in a structural relationship to the public that is unusual: every household pays directly for an institution none of them owns. Accordingly, the BBC's editorial pressures are unusual too — it is criticised simultaneously by all major political camps, which is either a sign of balance or of a

Your turn II

particular kind of blandness, depending on whom you ask. More specifically, the *inform-educate-entertain* mandate from 1927 survives because it is vague enough to be useful and old enough to be defensible. In this regard, the BBC's resilience is the resilience of an institution that has been continuously slightly embarrassing to power. The lazy part of calling the BBC the most British institution is that it ignores the post-1945 NHS, which has done at least as much to shape what *British* means in the second half of the twentieth century. Both are needed.

Reflect I

- I can identify the writer's argumentative move in a cultural-history essay.
- I can use 4 formal academic discourse markers.
- I can write a 250-word cultural-essay paragraph past tourist cliché.

Further reading / listening I

- BBC History — accessible long-form articles.
- The Guardian — *Long reads* on British institutions.